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Read Less News

Good morning, Pro Briefers!

Most people think of helium as the gas that fills party balloons.

But helium is much more than that - it runs some of the most critical technology in the world - from the machines that build smartphone chips, to hospital MRI scanners, to the hard drives powering AI data centers.

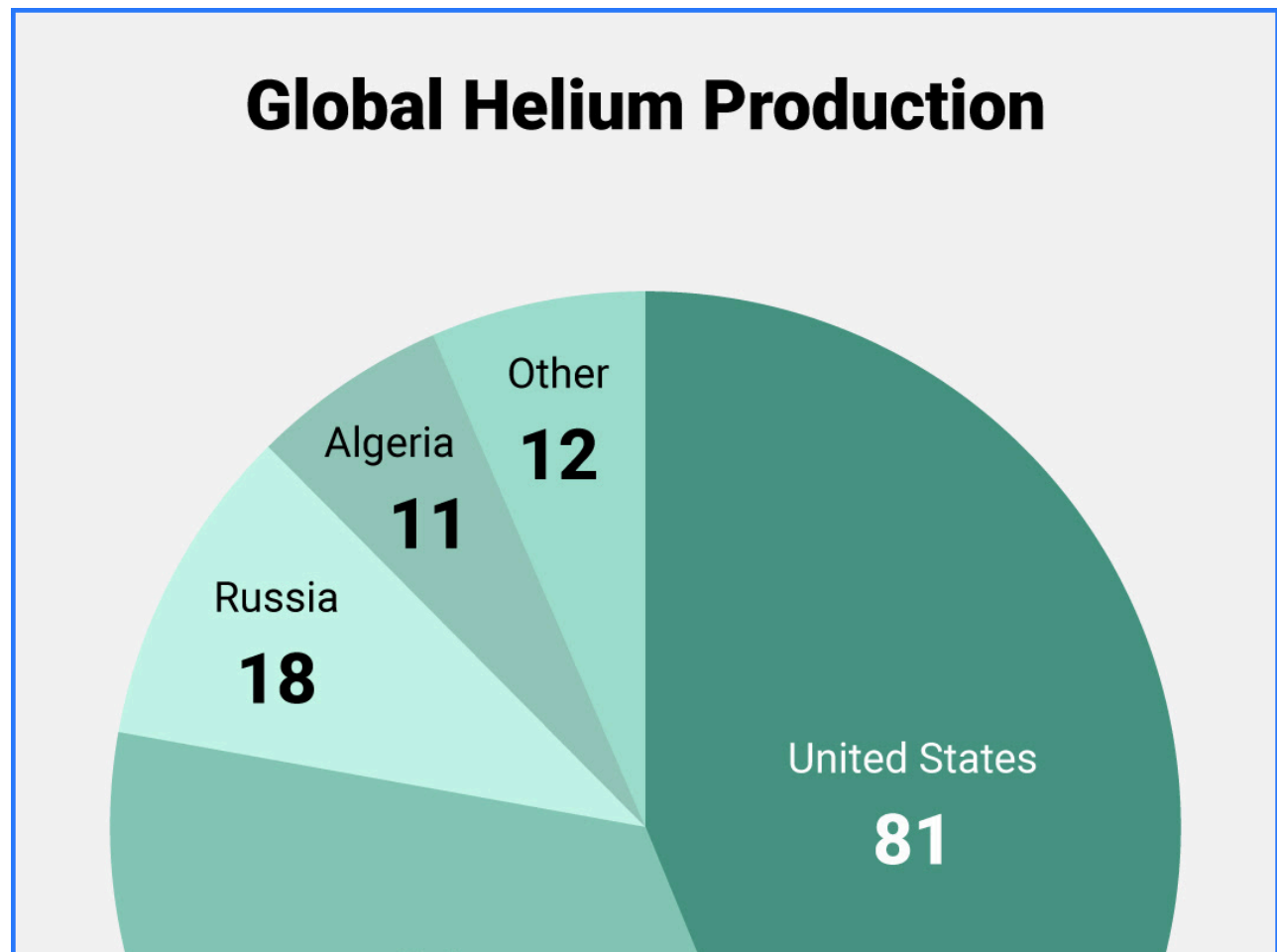
The problem: War in Iran has reduced the supply of helium globally.

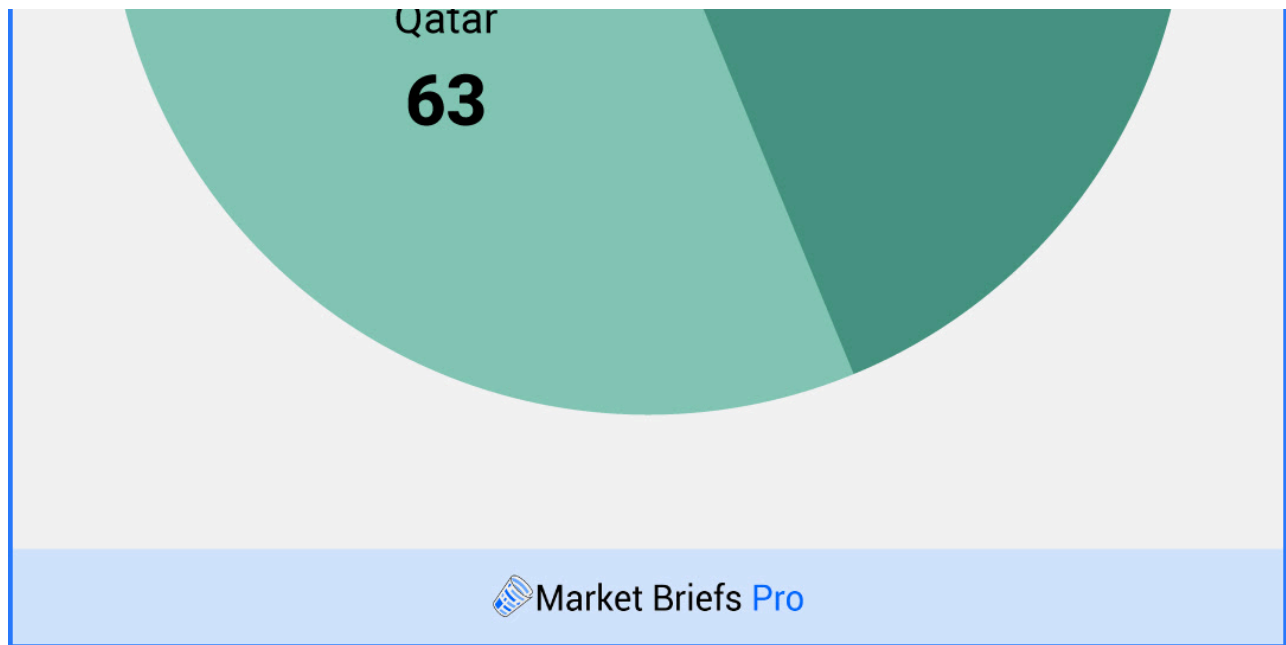
Battle operations in the region have knocked out infrastructure of all types - including those that supply helium.

Qatar's Ras Laffan complex - where roughly a quarter to a third of all the helium on Earth is produced, was taken offline as a result.

- Within days, all three of Qatar's helium plants went dark - meaning production in the region has largely stopped.

At the same time, Iran locked down the Strait of Hormuz - the narrow waterway connecting the Persian Gulf to the ocean.





Data *via* The Oregon Group

In simple terms - it is very difficult for any supplies to get out of the region, including helium.

And even if the war officially ended tomorrow, its impacts will lower the supply for potentially years, not just in the short term.

But this is actually creating a potential investing opportunity that we have identified as a Broad Market Shift:

The sudden removal of roughly one-third of global helium production, combined with a shipping blockade and no backup supply, is creating potential opportunities for investors in helium distributors and companies that use or need it.

Let's break down what's happening and why investors may want to pay attention.

ANALYST TAKE

Tickers we're tracking:

Market leader: LIN

Revenue driver: APD

Insulated tech: MU

Why The Shortage Matters

The helium shortage matters because there is no alternative.

It can't be manufactured or swapped for another gas.

Helium is extracted as a byproduct when natural gas is processed - and once it escapes into the atmosphere, it floats away permanently.

And each day without new production is a day of supply that never comes back.

The U.S. government used to maintain a strategic helium stockpile, but it was sold to a private buyer in 2024 for \$460 million.

Today, most chip factories carry enough helium for about seven days, and the global pipeline has a 45 day backlog.

But remember, helium is a gas, so the longer it sits, the more gas escapes into the atmosphere.

Today, there is a ceasefire between the U.S., Israel, and Iran - but the infrastructure is already damaged.

- Qatar's energy chief said repairs could take three to five years, with estimated revenue losses of roughly \$20 billion.

However, as of April 10th, reports indicate that the Strait is still closed - so even though there might not be new damage, nothing can travel by tanker ship.

Plus, the entire AI industry is getting more complex, which means it needs better chips.

Better chips = better cooling, something only helium can provide.

- South Korean manufacturers Samsung and SK Hynix rely on Qatar for roughly two-thirds of their helium imports.

More than 35,000 MRI machines worldwide still rely on liquid helium for cooling.

Newer helium-free models exist, but it could be expensive and take a generation to replace the majority of them.

The bottom line: The world needs this helium, and fast - so where is it going to come from?

There are a few suppliers and companies that have key advantages to potentially profit from this shift.

Let's break down those potential opportunities next.

MARKET LEADER

Building A Helium Moat

The first company to benefit will be those who can still produce helium as demand continues to rise.

Linde (LIN) holds the biggest slice of the global helium distribution business at around 24.5% - more than any other company on the planet.

What does it do? It produces gases like nitrogen, oxygen, hydrogen, and of course, helium.

What sets Linde apart is its infrastructure.

Linde Industrial Gases Overview

Atmospheric Gases

- Nitrogen • Oxygen • Argon
- Rare gases: Krypton, Neon, Xenon

Ne

N₂

Xe



Ar

O₂

Kr

Process Gases

- Hydrogen
- Carbon dioxide
- Helium
- Carbon monoxide
- Acetylene
- Propane



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Data via Linde's Investor Presentation

In July 2025, the company brought a huge underground storage facility online in Beaumont, Texas - one of just three salt caverns in the world designed to hold helium.

With no government stockpile left, Linde effectively created its own strategic reserve.

- And, the production is happening far away from the war, which lowers the risk of disruption.

That gives it a storage advantage that is difficult to replicate.

- No competitor can create a stockpile of helium overnight or even in the next few years.

Linde also has customers around the world, including in the U.S. and Europe - and prices for helium are expected to rise.

Linde Historical Performance

Results 1993-2025



Data [via](#) Linde's Investor Presentation

Rising prices mean more revenue for Linde, as customers pay more due to the shortage.

If the crisis drags on for months, Linde's long-term contracts will renew at a higher price.

If it resolves faster than expected, the physical damage to Qatar's facilities still means a permanent 14% reduction in output for years - keeping supply tight.

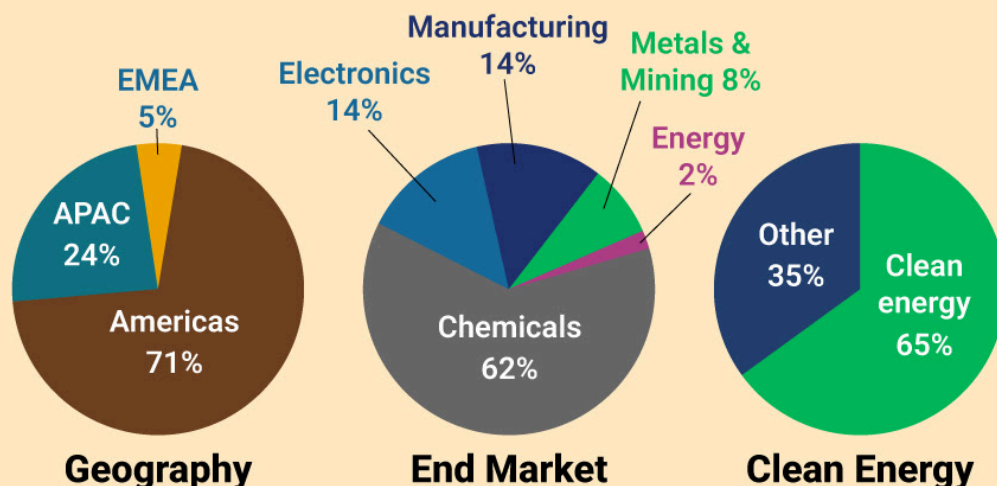
And if things escalate further, the ability to get helium becomes even more valuable.

In short, Linde may benefit no matter which direction this conflict takes, so investors will want to keep an eye on it as this shift progresses.

Linde Growth Backlog

SOG Backlog-\$7.3B

- ✓ Contractual growth
- ✓ Secure cash flow
- ✓ Double-digit IRR
- ✓ High-quality customers
- ✓ Increases network density



SOP Backlog-\$2.7B

- ✓ Contractual growth
- ✓ Secure cash flow
- ✓ Double-digit IRR
- ✓ High-quality customers
- ✓ Primarily engineering and procurement services

Exit strategy: If the Strait of Hormuz fully reopens within 30 days - with insurance companies resuming normal coverage - Linde may lose its ability to keep prices high.

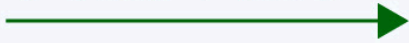
The same goes if Russia, a major producer of helium, starts cutting helium deals directly with buyers in Europe or Asia, bypassing Linde's distribution network (we'll discuss this more later).

On the tech side, if tech companies make a chip-cooling system that doesn't need helium, long-term demand may shift.

And if Qatar repairs its factories faster than expected, supply could increase quickly, lowering helium prices.

Linde plc (LIN)

1 Year Price



\$504.81
(13.19%)



REVENUE DRIVER

Helium's Money Maker

Similar to Linde, Air Products (APD) is an industrial gas producer that makes helium.

While Linde owns the biggest part of the helium market, the largest part of Air Products revenue comes from helium.

- It owns the majority of global helium production plants and pioneered the extraction tech to produce helium.
- It earns roughly 7.5% of its total sales from helium, about triple the exposure of its closest competitors.

What does that mean? When helium prices move, Air Products feels it more than anyone else in the sector.

Air Products Financial Summary			
Millions of U.S. Dollars, except for per share data			
FOR THE FISCAL YEAR ENDED 30 SEPTEMBER			
(from continuing operations, unless otherwise indicated)			
	2025	2024	Change
GAPP			
Sales	\$12,037	\$12,101	(1%)
Operating income (loss)	(\$877)	\$4,466	**
Operating margin	(7.3%)	36.9%	**
Return on capital	(0.9%)	10.8%	**
NON-GAPP			
Adjusted operating income (loss)	\$2,858	\$2,948	(3%)
Adjusted operating	22.5%	24.4%	(7%)

Adjusted operating margin	23.7%	24.4%	(70) bp
Adjusted return on capital	10.1%	11.3%	(120) bp
PER-SHARE			
GAAP earnings (loss) per share	(\$1.74)	\$17.24	**
Adjusted earnings per share	\$12.03	\$12.43	(3%)
Dividends declared per common share	\$7.14	\$7.06	1%

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Data [via](#) Air Product's 10-K

Think of it like this: If helium prices double, a company with 1% helium exposure barely notices.

A company with 7.5% exposure sees a meaningful jump in earnings.

Air Products operates a similar business model to Linde - distributing helium to major customers under long-term contracts and collecting fees along the way, like a toll road.

That size works in its favor for this shift - more of its revenue comes from helium, which means it could earn more in the near future.

So if shortages persist, Air Products may offer investors the highest earnings leverage to rising helium prices in the entire industrial gas space.

Air Products Key Priorities

Unlock earnings growth

Adjusted EPS up 10% in first quarter; affirming our full year adjusted EPS guidance

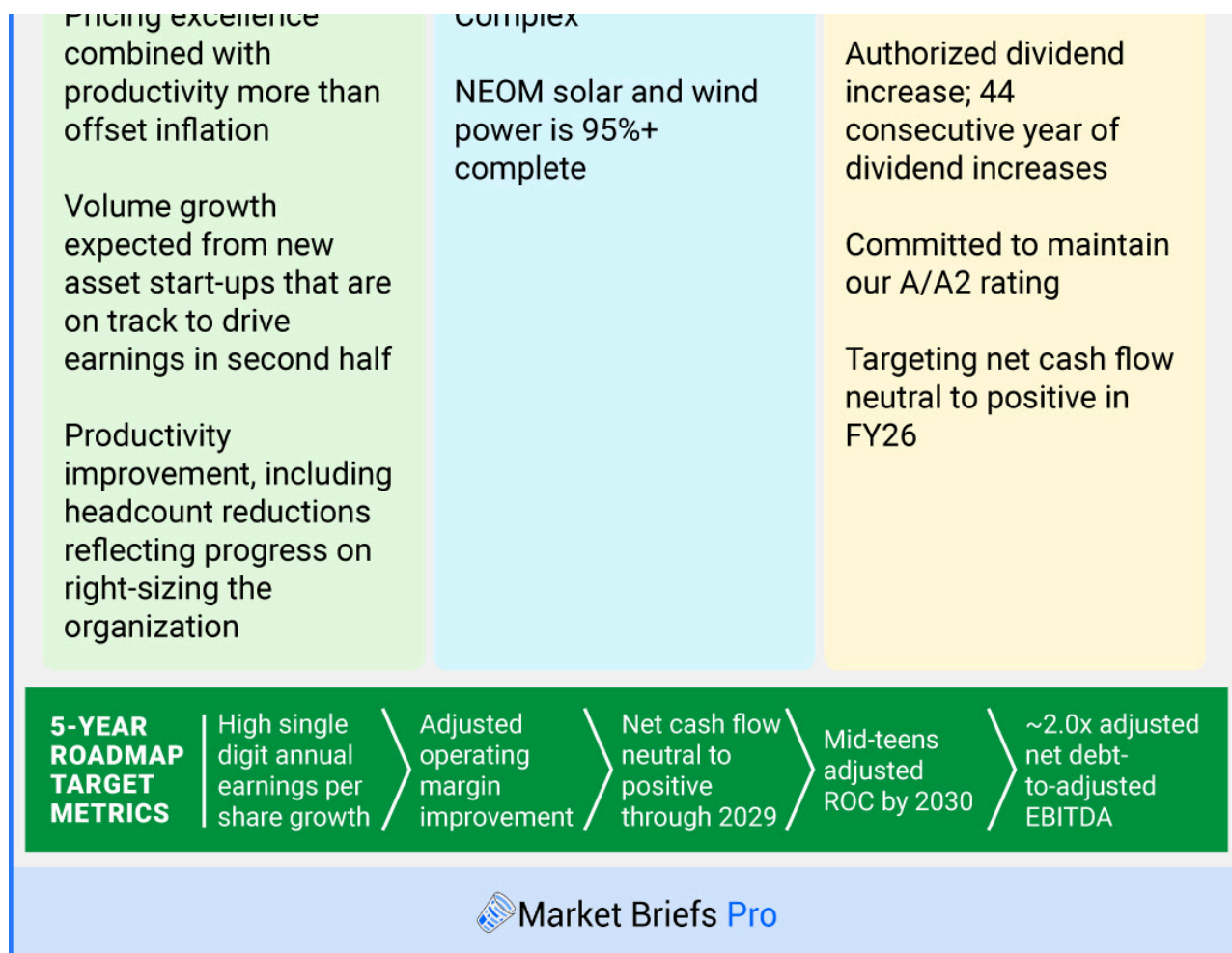
Pricing excellence

Optimize large projects

Announced advanced negotiations with Yara on Louisiana Clean Energy Complex and NEOM Green Hydrogen Complex

Maintain capital discipline

Disciplined capital deployment to fund sustained growth; on track to reduce capex from prior year



Data [via](#) Air Product's Investor Presentation

Exit strategy: APD has existing contracts that were signed before the war started - so as prices rise, it's not able to increase prices as those deals are locked in.

It may have provisions in those contracts that allow it to adjust prices upwards due to geopolitical issues, but this is unknown, as those contracts are private.

But if those provisions do not exist, it may not fully benefit from the helium shortage making prices rise.

Air Products & Chemicals, Inc. (APD)

1 Year Price

\$299.24

(10.75%)



 Briefs Terminal

Data [via](#) Briefs Terminal

Its hydrogen joint venture with Saudi Aramco, the world's largest oil producer, could also hit delays, which may mean it doesn't see the explosive growth that Wall Street expects.

And if activist investors force a breakup of the company, separating its helium and hydrogen business, it could strip out the combined growth story making APD attractive right now.

INSULATED TECH

The Chip Giant

If chip makers can't get the helium they need, chip production falls.

But there's one chip maker that may be more insulated to this helium shortage than most: Micron (MU).

Its manufacturing sites in Idaho and Virginia pull helium from domestic and non-Gulf sources, so cost jumps on helium won't be as high for them.

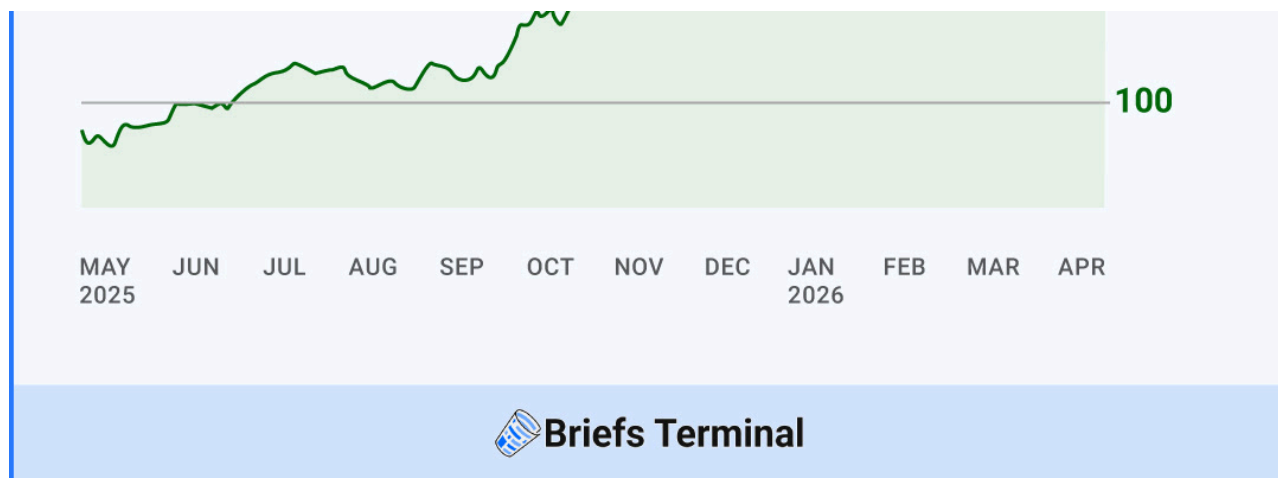
- Costs related to helium are expected to jump for Micron about 1.15-1.5x versus a potential 3-5x jump for Korean rivals.

Why does that gap matter? Memory chips are a commodity business - when one producer's costs spike and others stay flat, the lower-cost producer gains pricing power and market share.

Other chip producers are now forced to make tough decisions about where to allocate their shrinking helium supply, and Micron doesn't have that issue.

And if they can't produce their chips, companies will turn to other chip makers like Micron that are still producing.





Data [via Briefs Terminal](#)

So every chip that a global competitor can't produce is one that benefits Micron's bottom line.

Micron and Samsung were nearly tied in HBM production before this crisis started - HBM is the type of memory chip AI needs for short-term memory.

The helium shortage is speeding up a competitive shift that was years in the making.

In short, Micron may emerge from this crisis with a structurally stronger position in the memory chip market than it had going in, so investors will want to keep it in mind for the long term.

Exit strategy: Micron's edge depends on its Korean rivals staying disadvantaged.

If Samsung and SK Hynix lock in long-term helium contracts from non-Qatar sources, the competitive gap closes.

Demand for AI memory chips could also peak before Micron fully capitalizes - especially if Samsung catches up on next-gen chip yields.

A broader recession would hurt too - Memory chip prices are cyclical, and falling average sales prices could overwhelm any advantages Micron gets from the helium shortage.

GEOPOLITICS

Other Helium Players

Roughly 30% of the world's helium comes out of the Middle East - but where does the rest

Nearly 60% of the world's helium comes out of the Middle East - but where does the rest come from?

Other top producers include Russia, Canada, the U.S., and Algeria.

Russia in particular is a major producer of helium and is in a unique geopolitical position.

Tankers from Russia can pass through the Strait of Hormuz without issue, as the country is an ally to Iran.

Plus, Russia's Amur Gas Processing Plant sits right on the Chinese border and is built to produce 60 million cubic meters of helium annually.

- At full capacity, that would make it the single largest helium production facility anywhere.

That means Moscow has access to both its own domestic output and Qatari supply - a combination no other country can match right now.

Sectoral Helium Usage

Breakdown of U.S. helium consumption by end-use sectors (in percentage)

**Analytical, engineering, lab,
science, specialty gases**

22

**Controlled atmospheres,
fiber optics, semiconductors**

17

Lifting gas

17

**Magnetic resonance
imaging (MRI)**

15

Aerospace

9

Welding

8

Diving

5

Leak detection

5

Other applications

2

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Data via USGS

- Helium flowing from Russia to China was already surging 60% per year before any of this started.

The long-term effect? The helium market is splitting along geopolitical lines - Russia and allies on one side, the U.S. and Western nations on the other - much like China's dominance over rare earth minerals reshaped that market years ago.

It's worth noting: These are not really investable opportunities for American investors.

But, staying aware of what's going on in the broader helium market can help investors to make smarter decisions.

RISKS

How This Shift Could Change

The most obvious risk is a faster-than-expected resolution.

If the Strait of Hormuz reopens quickly and Qatar brings production back online, the price premium for helium will disappear and getting it won't be much of an issue.

Like we mentioned above, geopolitics is at play here. There's always a chance that countries like the U.S. limit where helium can be bought from.

- The U.S. has already done this with Russian goods and investments due to the war in Ukraine.

And even if Micron benefits from helium dynamics, a broad market sell off could impact its ability to make money.

- If demand for chips falls suddenly, investors may move their capital into other opportunities temporarily.

Lastly, while there is no substitute for helium today, a prolonged shortage could push research labs to develop alternatives that don't yet exist.

Investors will want to consider all of these risks, as this shift is only just beginning, and has a lot of room to change in the short term.

REVIEW

Helium's Shortage Is Here To Stay

While the rest of the world has been watching oil prices, helium supply has been running thin.

The Middle East makes a huge amount of helium every year - and without it, medicine and AI could take a hit.

But it also created an opportunity for other companies making helium away from the conflict, and for those who use it, and are less exposed to the war.

Now, companies that move helium around the world and chipmakers with the least exposure to the shortage may be positioned to benefit from this shift.

This is a long-term structural change - changes will not happen overnight.

In the meantime, investors who are willing to be patient may be able to take advantage of some unique investment opportunities that are forming right now.



- Market Briefs Pro Team

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Our mission? It's simple - to help you be better with money.

Included interviews have been edited for length and clarity.